

The Velvet Vault

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Brass Stair

It started, as most things did in the Library Labyrinth, with Maya noticing something she was not supposed to notice.

They had come to return a stack of reference books Alana had borrowed for her ongoing project on cloud architecture. The Returns desk stood at the south end of the main hall, staffed by a small mechanical sorting cart that clicked and hummed as it processed each title. The girls knew the process by heart: slide the book, wait for the chime, take your receipt.

Maya slid Alana's first book. Chime.

She slid the second. Chime.

While waiting for the third receipt, she leaned sideways past the desk and looked at the narrow panel behind it. The wall there was dark wood paneled in a grid of squares, ordinary and dull. Except for one square in the lower corner, which had a brass handle shaped like a book spine.

"There's a door back here," Maya said.

"That's the filing access hatch," Alana said. "Standard maintenance infrastructure."

"It has a handle shaped like a book."

Alana reconsidered. "That is unusual."

SPARK floated over and scanned the panel. His optic lens narrowed to a pinpoint. "Correction: that is not a filing hatch. That is a staircase entrance. Depth: significant. Atmosphere below: velvet-adjacent."

"Velvet-adjacent," Natalia repeated. "What does that mean?"

"Expensive and slightly mysterious," SPARK said. "My circuits are very excited."

The sorting cart finished receipts and wheeled itself to a charging dock. The hall was quiet. Natalia glanced left and right, then crouched next to the brass handle and tugged gently.

The panel swung outward without resistance, and a warm amber light exhaled upward like a sleeping sigh.

Below them, a staircase descended in a gentle spiral, each step edged in tarnished brass that caught the light and turned it honey-gold. The walls on either side were covered in deep red velvet, slightly faded at the seams, soft as an old cardigan.

Pinned to the top step was a card. Natalia lifted it.

THE VELVET VAULT FIRST EDITIONS ONLY ENTRY BY INVITATION

Below that, in letters so small they had to lean together to read them:

Or by genuine curiosity. The door decides.

"The door invited us," Maya said.

Alana checked her watch. "We have two free hours."

SPARK's chest display showed a single golden key turning slowly. "Recommend we accept the invitation."

Natalia held the card to the light for a moment, then tucked it carefully into her pocket.

"We go carefully," she said.

And they stepped through together, into the warm amber glow below.

Chapter 2 — Velvet and Silence

The staircase was longer than it looked from above.

Each step curved gently inward, so descending felt less like going down and more like being welcomed. The velvet walls muffled all sound from the library above, and by the third spiral the only thing they could hear was their own quiet breathing and the faint hum of SPARK's flight mechanism.

"Temperature stable," SPARK reported. "Humidity optimal for aged paper. Scent notes: leather, cedar, and something I can only describe as the inside of a very important dream."

"That last part isn't a real measurement," Alana said.

"I know. I included it anyway."

The staircase opened without warning into a room so large that Natalia stopped at the threshold and simply looked.

The Velvet Vault was round and double-storied, its ceiling lost in soft shadows above a ring of suspended amber lanterns. Shelves lined every inch of curved wall, floor to balcony, each one edged in the same dark red velvet as the stairway. Glass doors protected each shelf section, fogged just enough to hint at what lay behind them: spines of every color, some narrow as a whisper, some broad as a shoebox, some wrapped in protective cloth the way you might wrap something precious for a long journey.

Between shelves hung velvet ropes on brass posts, the kind used to mark sacred or exclusive territory.

"A velvet-rope vault," Maya said. "In a library."

"Reserved access," Alana said softly. "For first-edition volumes."

SPARK moved his light forward. Dust motes drifted through the beam like lazy planets. In the center of the room stood a single reading table with three chairs and one floating perch shaped exactly right for SPARK. On the table sat an open ledger, ink still wet on its last entry:

Today's Visitors: expected. Purpose: to be determined. Requirement: demonstrate readiness.

"Readiness for what?" Maya asked.

The ledger answered by writing a new line:

Readiness is not speed. Begin at the first rope.

All four of them looked left. A velvet rope stretched across the first aisle, and above it hung a sign in careful gold lettering:

AISLE OF THE PATIENT READER Do not pull. Do not push. Wait until the way opens.

Maya's hands went automatically to the rope. She stopped herself.

"Patience," Natalia said quietly.

"Right. I know. I'm working on it."

SPARK dimmed his lights to a gentle amber. "No rush," he said, and for once he sounded like he meant it completely.

They stood at the rope together and waited to see what the vault would do next.

Chapter 3 — The Aisle of the Patient Reader

The rope did not move for four minutes.

Alana counted. Maya shifted her weight from foot to foot. SPARK hovered perfectly still, which was not naturally easy for him.

"Is waiting supposed to feel like this?" Maya asked.

"Like what?" Natalia said.

"Like my brain is trying to run in six directions at once."

"Yes," Alana said. "That is patience. The brain wants to act and you choose to hold."

"You say that very calmly."

"I practice."

On the two-minute mark, words had appeared on the velvet rope itself in small stitched letters:

Something good is coming. Let it come at its own pace.

Maya read it and let out a long breath through her nose.

On the four-minute mark, the rope loosened. Not dramatically. It simply dropped one notch, the way a shoulder drops when tension leaves it. Then it unhooked from the brass post on the right side and looped itself gently around the post instead, clearing the aisle.

The first shelf inside became visible.

It held twelve books, each behind glass, each with a spine that glowed faintly with a color different from the ambient amber of the room. Blues and greens and one deep rose. Tags on each glass door read FIRST EDITION in embossed letters, and beneath that, much smaller: read me when ready, not when rushed.

Natalia bent to read one title: The Still River Atlas, Vol. I.

"An explorer's atlas from before modern cartography," Alana murmured. "If that's a genuine first printing, it's extraordinarily rare."

SPARK scanned a second volume. "This one has luminescent ink in the illustrations. Original technique, likely from an era before printed light was replicated."

"Can we touch them?" Maya asked.

"Not yet," Natalia said. She had noticed something: a handwritten note taped inside the nearest glass door.

These books open for those who wait. They open wider for those who ask without grabbing. They will not open at all for those who consider speed a virtue here.

Maya put both hands behind her back voluntarily.

"Good instinct," Alana said.

They moved through the aisle slowly, reading every spine, looking at every cover detail visible through the glass, asking questions quietly as if they were in a library much smaller than this one. They did not test the doors. They did not hurry.

By the time they reached the end of the aisle, a second rope had already unhooked itself ahead of them.

SPARK's display showed two small words:

Aisle Two.

And above it, the sign read:

AISLE OF THE UNAFRAID READER Some of these books are very old. Some of them remember things that are difficult. Do not look away.

Chapter 4 — The Aisle of the Unafraid Reader

The second aisle was narrower and darker than the first.

The amber lanterns here had been replaced by small reading lamps at shelf height, throwing short pools of light that left wide stretches of shadow between. The velvet on the walls was a deeper red here, almost burgundy, and the glass doors on the shelves were plain rather than fogged. Through them, the books looked different: some had water-stained covers, some had torn spines carefully repaired, some had burn marks on their edges that suggested narrow escapes.

"These books have been through things," Maya said.

"Difficult histories," Alana agreed. "Floods, fires, wars, decades of neglect."

SPARK hovered close to one glass door and read the condition tag aloud. "Water damage to forty percent of pages, year unknown. Partial text restoration complete. Surviving content irreplaceable."

Natalia felt a tightening in her chest that was not quite sadness and not quite awe. Something between.

The ledger note for this aisle was etched directly into the velvet wall in gold thread:

A rare book's wounds are its whole story. Reading it means accepting both.

A new challenge made itself known at the center of the aisle: a single book sat on a reading stand outside its case, open to a middle page. The text was dense and the subject matter was visible even from a distance. It was a historical account of a terrible flood that had destroyed an entire archive. The words were not softened. The account was direct.

Beside the stand was a question card:

Can you read this without turning away? Not to be unmoved, but to stay present.

Maya read the card, squared her shoulders, and stepped forward.

She read the page. Her expression went through several changes: discomfort, grief, then a quiet steadiness. She did not skip lines. She did not close the book early.

When she looked up, her voice was level. "I read it."

"We know," Natalia said gently.

"It was hard."

"Yes."

"I'm glad it survived."

The stand's book closed itself softly, and the glass case in front of them clicked open. Inside sat a volume bound in plain brown cloth, its spine re-stitched in careful thread. A slip inside the door read:

Courage is choosing to understand what is difficult. You understood.

Alana placed her hand briefly on the case's door. "We are not taking it. We are only acknowledging it."

Something clicked softly behind them.

The third rope had come down on its own.

The aisle ahead glowed the warmest amber yet, and its sign read:

AISLE OF THE KIND READER The test here is not what you do. It is how you do it.

Chapter 5 — The Aisle of the Kind Reader

The third aisle smelled different from the others: warmer, with something like paper and honey and the faint trace of dried flowers.

Along the shelves here, the books were interspersed with small objects placed with care: a dried violet pressed under glass, a tiny wooden bird on a book's crown, a folded square of cloth tucked between spines. Each one was tagged with a slim card that read: left here by a previous visitor.

"Someone decorated this aisle," Maya said.

"Many someones," Natalia said. "Over time."

SPARK scanned a card. "Oldest dated object: eighty-three years. A folded letter from a child to a book they had to return."

He read aloud softly: "Dear Red Adventure Book, I wish you could come home with me but I know you belong to everyone. I will come back and you will be here and that is almost as good."

The vault was very quiet after that.

At the center of the third aisle stood not a reading stand but a low bench, and on the bench sat a single book lying

face-down. Beside it, a card:

A reader left this mid-chapter. They were called away unexpectedly. They meant to return. Show this book the kindness they couldn't.

Natalia sat on the bench. She did not rush. She picked up the book carefully and turned it right-side up. She found its last read page by the slight bow of the spine, then placed a proper ribbon bookmark between the pages instead of folding the corner.

She closed it gently and set it down.

Nothing dramatic happened. No lock clicked. No rope dropped. But the air changed in the way air sometimes does when something small and right occurs: a quieting, like a room settling when it finally feels safe.

Then Alana heard something.

A rustling from the far end of the aisle. Not pages turning. Not a mechanism. More like fabric shifting, or many pieces of paper moving together in a gentle wave.

"SPARK," she said.

"I hear it too," he confirmed. His light shifted toward the sound.

At the end of the third aisle, where a fourth velvet rope had hung all along without any of them noticing, the rope was gone. In its place stood an archway, and through the archway shimmered a room they had not seen before.

The rustling came from inside.

Maya looked at the others.

"All three trials," she said. "Patience, courage, kindness."

Natalia nodded. "We demonstrated them."

"Not performed them," Alana said quietly. "There's a difference."

SPARK moved his light toward the archway. The warmth from inside reached them even at a distance.

"Someone is waiting," he said.

They walked through together.

Chapter 6 — Patchwork

The room beyond the archway was not what any of them expected.

They had imagined a vault guardian would be stern: a figure in formal dress, or a mechanical gatekeeper with strict rules and a clipboard. Instead, the room held a small fire in a round hearth, three mismatched armchairs arranged in a welcoming semicircle, and a teakettle that hummed to itself on a low table.

And in the largest chair sat Patchwork.

They knew her name without being told it, which was the vault's way of introducing someone important.

Patchwork was roughly the size and shape of a generous armchair herself. She was made entirely of cloth: hundreds of cloth pieces stitched and layered into a figure with a round body, two arm-like extensions that rested on the chair's arms, and a face composed of fabric scraps in different shades of cream, gold, and faded rose. Her eyes were two large mother-of-pearl buttons that caught the firelight and shimmered with intelligence.

But it was her covering that held them still for a long moment.

Every patch of her was different, and up close, they were not simply cloth squares. They were paper sewn into cloth, laminated and preserved into soft patchwork. Small printed cards, forms, slips.

Maya leaned in and read the nearest one: Overdue Notice — The Lighthouse Keeper's Garden — Two Weeks Late.

She read another: Returned Past Due — A Book of Small Moons — Three Months Late.

She stepped back. "Those are library slips."

"Overdue library slips," Alana said.

Patchwork's button eyes tilted toward them, and her voice, when she spoke, was like several pages turning at once, layered and warm.

"Every one of them mine," she said. "I stitched myself together from them, a long time ago. It seemed only fair."

Natalia sat down in the nearest armchair without being invited, because it felt like the right thing to do. "What do you mean?"

"I was a reader once," Patchwork said. "Not a keeper. Not a guardian. Just a reader who borrowed more than she remembered to return." Her fabric hands shifted in her lap. "I loved every book I borrowed. I simply loved other things too, and time slipped past me the way it does when you are not careful with it."

SPARK landed gently on the edge of the hearth. "But you became keeper of the vault."

"The vault chose me," Patchwork said. "Because I knew what it was to borrow something precious and not treat the returning as equally precious. I know both sides."

She looked at each of them in turn.

"And now," she said, "I need to decide if I am ready to let it be both sides again."

Chapter 7 — Stitched From Slips

The tea was warm and tasted of chamomile and something faintly like old ink, which should not have been pleasant but was.

Patchwork poured it herself, her cloth hands managing the kettle with surprising steadiness. She gave SPARK a cup too, despite the fact that he could not drink it. He held it and said it was the best tea he had never tasted.

"Tell us about the slips," Natalia said.

Patchwork set down her cup. "When I was fourteen, I borrowed eleven books in one summer. I was going through a very reading summer. You know those?"

"Yes," all three sisters said at once.

"I borrowed them with every intention of returning them promptly. But summer moved differently than I expected. I read slowly because I wanted to stay in each book as long as possible. And when I finally brought them back, the library had seven overdue notices waiting in my name. Then more the following season. I was not irresponsible. I was simply a reader who did not understand that returning is part of the love."

She smoothed a patch on her side with one hand. The slip there read: Three Weeks Late — Songs of the Mountain Library.

"What happened?" Maya asked.

"The labyrinth noticed me," Patchwork said. "Libraries notice readers who love deeply but return carelessly. The vault needed a keeper who would understand both the value of rare things and the pain of delayed returns. So it offered me a choice: become keeper, or remain as I was."

"And you chose keeper," Alana said.

"I chose keeper. And as part of the becoming, the vault stitched my old overdue slips into me. Not as punishment. As reminder." Her button eyes held a steady light. "Every morning when I wake, I feel each one. Every evening when I rest, I count them. They are not shame. They are my record."

SPARK hummed softly. "And the vault judged you not by your lateness but by your love of the books."

Patchwork was quiet for a moment. "That is what I have always believed. But I am not certain I believe it about myself."

Natalia looked up sharply. "What do you mean?"

Patchwork set both cloth hands on her knees. "For the last many years, I have been reluctant to open the vault to

new readers. Not because I distrust others. Because I fear they will borrow and not return, and I remember how that felt to be the cause of."

The fire crackled.

"I have been protecting the books by keeping them hidden," Patchwork continued. "But I wonder if I have also been hiding from my own history."

The room sat with that for a moment, the way you sit with something true and heavy.

"We came here," Maya said slowly, "to learn why the vault is closed."

Patchwork nodded. "And now you know."

Chapter 8 — The Books That Remember

While Patchwork refilled the tea, SPARK quietly mapped the vault's inner geography, projecting a soft schematic in the air. The Velvet Vault had three aisle sections they had walked, a reading room, and then this inner chamber. Beyond the inner chamber, according to SPARK's scan, lay one more room.

"What is through there?" Alana asked, nodding toward the door on the far wall.

Patchwork turned. "The deep shelves. Where the rarest first editions wait."

"Wait for what?"

"To be read." Patchwork set the kettle down. "That is the problem, you see. A book that is never read is not fully alive. It is preserved, but it is also alone." She touched a slip-patch on her forearm. "I keep them safe. But I have not let them be read in a very long time."

"How long?" Natalia asked.

Patchwork considered. "Long enough that some of them have stopped trusting that they will be read again."

Maya straightened in her chair. "Books can lose trust?"

"The rarest ones can. They have been disappointed before. Displayed but not opened. Stored but not loved."

Patchwork rose slowly from her chair, her patchwork body rustling softly as she moved. "Come."

She led them through the far door.

The deep shelves were smaller than they had expected: a single curved room lined wall to wall with books protected not by glass but by a subtle amber glow that pulsed slowly, like sleeping breaths. Every spine was extraordinary. Colors and textures and print styles from across many eras, each unique, each vibrating at its own quiet frequency.

But none of them glowed outright. They were muted, dim, folded in on themselves.

"They used to glow brighter," Patchwork said softly. "When readers came regularly."

SPARK adjusted his light to its lowest setting, instinctively respectful. "How do they reactivate?"

Patchwork touched the spine of one volume gently, and it pulsed once under her cloth finger. "They respond to being read aloud. Not recited. Not performed. Read with genuine attention, as you would to a friend." She withdrew her hand. "But I have been afraid to attempt it myself. My voice carries the weight of all my slips, and I feared the books would feel that weight and close further."

Natalia stepped closer to the shelf. One book, slim and cloth-bound, seemed slightly brighter than the rest: a warm rose color that flickered like an ember.

She looked at Patchwork. "May I try?"

Patchwork's button eyes reflected the rose glow. "That is why you passed the three aisles," she said. "Patience, courage, kindness. You are exactly the right kind of reader."

Natalia reached for the slim volume with both hands.

Chapter 9 — Reading Aloud

The book in Natalia's hands was titled *A Small History of Generous Mornings*.

The cover was worn at the corners, the cloth faded from rose to a soft blush, but the spine was intact and the pages turned without crumbling. Natalia stood in the center of the deep-shelf room with her sisters on either side, SPARK hovering quietly behind, and Patchwork at the door with her cloth hands folded.

Natalia opened to the first page.

She did not read immediately. She looked at the text for a moment, at the typeface that was slightly uneven in the way of books set by hand a long time ago, at the small illustration at the chapter head: a window and morning light coming through it.

Then she read.

She did not use a performance voice. She did not dramatize. She simply spoke the words as they were, giving each sentence the time it needed, pausing at commas the way the author had intended, letting the rhythm live.

The book in her hands warmed after the first paragraph. Not uncomfortably, just perceptibly warmer, the way a stone warms in afternoon sun.

By the second page, the rose glow of the spine had brightened. Around it on the shelf, the neighboring books stirred. Not dramatically. Slightly, the way sleeping children shift when warmth enters a room.

Alana watched a blue-bound volume two shelves up pulse once, twice, three times in slow rhythm.

Maya realized she was holding her breath and let it out carefully, not wanting to interrupt.

SPARK's display had gone silent. He was simply watching.

Natalia read for four pages before she stopped at a natural pause.

The deep-shelf room was different now. The muted amber glow had warmed into something closer to candlelight. Not blazing. Not transformed. But present in a way it had not been before.

Patchwork had moved without them noticing. She stood now beside Natalia, her cloth hands clasped, her button eyes very bright.

"They remembered," she said.

"They were remembering the whole time," Natalia said gently. "They just needed to hear it was still safe to glow."

Patchwork was quiet. A fold in the fabric of her face, near the button eyes, shifted in a way that was unmistakably feeling something difficult.

"I should have done this years ago," she said. "If I had let readers in, the books would not have dimmed."

"You were protecting them," Maya said.

"I was protecting myself." Patchwork's voice did not waver, but it was careful with itself. "The books paid the cost of my fear."

None of the girls offered comfort immediately. They let the honesty sit, which is what honest things need before they can heal.

It was SPARK who finally spoke.

"The books are still here," he said. "They are still listening."

Chapter 10 — What Patchwork Needed to Hear

Alana was the one who said it, because Alana was good at naming the precise thing.

"You need to forgive yourself," she said. "Not the books, not us, not the readers you kept away. Yourself."

Patchwork looked at her. "That sounds simple when you say it."

"It is not simple," Alana said. "I know it is not. I only mean that is the specific thing, so we are not confused about what we are working on."

Maya let out a small laugh that she quickly tried to contain. "She is always like this and it always helps."

Patchwork looked down at her patchwork body. Her cloth hands turned over slowly in her lap, the overdue slips catching the candlelight. "I have been carrying these slips as my testimony against myself. Every late return I ever caused. Every frustrated librarian, every reader who could not access a book because I had it too long."

"But they let you become keeper," Natalia said. "The vault chose you because of those slips, not despite them."

"I know."

"Do you believe it?"

Patchwork was very still for a long moment.

"I believe the vault chose correctly," she said. "I am still learning to believe I deserved it."

Natalia set *A Small History of Generous Mornings* on the reading table and turned to face Patchwork fully. "Tell me about one book you borrowed that you loved."

The question surprised Patchwork. Her button eyes shifted. "One?"

"Whichever comes first."

Patchwork was quiet for a moment, then: "A book called *The February Letters*. About a girl who wrote letters to the snow to ask it to stay longer. I borrowed it three times over three winters. Each time I kept it a week past due."

"Why?"

"Because I read it slowly. Because each time I read it I was at a different part of growing up, and it said different things to me."

"Did you love it?"

"Completely."

"Did you return it?"

"Every time."

Natalia waited.

Patchwork blinked her button eyes. "Every time," she repeated, as if hearing it for the first time. "I always returned it."

"You kept it carefully," Natalia said. "You loved it in the way things need to be loved. The returning was late but

the care was whole."

SPARK's display filled quietly with small golden squares, like a quilt being completed one patch at a time.

Patchwork looked at her own hands. One of the slips near her wrist read: Two Weeks Late — The February Letters.

She touched it, and for the first time, her touch was not heavy.

"I meant well," she said. It was not a defense. It was something she had not let herself say before.

"We know," Maya said. "The vault knew too."

Chapter 11 — The Vault Reopens

Patchwork made a decision slowly, the way someone makes a decision they have been approaching for a long time without naming it.

She rose from the reading chair and moved to the center of the deep-shelf room. Her cloth body rustled with the sound of many slips shifting. She stood beneath the highest amber lamp, which pulsed once in greeting.

"I want to reopen the vault," she said. "To all careful readers."

"Careful, not fast," Maya confirmed.

"Careful, not perfect," Patchwork added. "There is a difference. Perfect readers return on time and love nothing deeply. Careful readers love deeply and do their best with time."

Alana nodded. "Operationally sound criteria."

"How do we help?" Natalia asked.

Patchwork looked at each of them. "You already have. But there is one step I cannot take alone. Each book in the deep shelves must hear one more reading before the vault opens properly. Not all at once. Not performed. Just one page of each, read as you read that first one."

The deep shelf room held forty-six books.

They divided the work without being asked: Natalia took the shelves by the far wall, Maya took the center column, Alana took the shelves near the archway. SPARK moved between them, holding light at the right angle for each reader, keeping the pace unhurried.

They read for what felt like a long and pleasant afternoon.

Not every book was warm to the touch immediately. A few took two pages. One took three, and SPARK had to

softly remind Maya that patience was the first trial for a reason. But every book reached its glow.

Some were extraordinary. One slim volume of garden poetry practically vibrated when Alana opened it. A travel narrative Maya read surged into deep amber light at a paragraph about a traveler finding the right road after a long detour. Natalia read an illustrated natural history so slowly and attentively that by the final page, the illustrations had begun to move: birds shifting on their branches, leaves trembling.

Patchwork watched from the doorway, very still. Her slip-patches caught and reflected the growing warmth of forty-six awakening books until she glowed faintly herself: a patchwork lantern in a vault of rising light.

When they finished, the deep shelves were fully lit. Not blazing. Warm and steady, like a room on a winter evening when everything necessary is present.

Patchwork stepped into the room properly for the first time.

She looked at the glowing shelves, and the expression on her fabric face was not triumph. It was quieter than that.

It was relief arriving after a very long wait.

"Thank you," she said, to the books and to them together.

The vault's amber lamps pulsed once, in unison, like an answer.

Chapter 12 — The Sign by the Brass Stair

The velvet rope at the base of the brass staircase had a new sign when they returned to it.

It was different from the signs that had hung in the aisles. Those had been tests. This one was an announcement, written in Patchwork's looping stitch-work across a fresh length of velvet:

THE VELVET VAULT OPEN TO CAREFUL READERS PATIENCE WELCOME COURAGE VALUED
KINDNESS REQUIRED

Below that, in slightly smaller letters:

Late returns are understood. Careless ones are a conversation. All loved books find their way home.

Maya read it twice and grinned. "That last line is perfect."

"She wrote it herself," Natalia said. "You can tell by the stitch."

They were back in the main vault room, the one with the three aisles and the central reading table. Patchwork stood by the table with a ledger she had opened for the first time in many years. It was not a list of overdue notices. It was a visitor register, with columns for name, date, and one entry labeled what you love to read.

"I will need help with the first week," Patchwork said. "Learning the rhythm of welcoming readers again. I am not as rusty as I feared, but I am a little rusty."

"We can come Thursdays," Natalia said. "That is our labyrinth day."

"And Saturdays if the schedule allows," Alana added.

"I will optimize my schedule," SPARK announced. "I consider this a primary function."

Patchwork's button eyes tilted warmly. "You are very organized for a floating robot who carries tea he cannot drink."

"I contain multitudes," SPARK said.

As they prepared to ascend the brass stair, Natalia paused at the reading table and looked at the open ledger. She picked up the pen and wrote the first entry:

Maya, Alana, Natalia, SPARK — Allen Girls Adventures. What we love to read: all of it.

Patchwork looked at the entry for a long moment.

"I once worried," she said slowly, "that admitting I was late meant I did not deserve to love books the way I do."

"And now?" Natalia asked.

Patchwork smoothed a slip-patch on her forearm: Two Weeks Late — The February Letters. "Now I think loving books and being imperfect about time are both honest things. The vault did not want a perfect keeper. It wanted one who understood."

"You understood," Alana said.

"I am still understanding," Patchwork said. "But I am doing it with the lights on now."

The amber lanterns glowed warmly above them. From the deep shelves behind the archway came the quiet pulse of forty-six first editions, resting and ready, waiting without anxiety for the readers who would come.

They climbed the brass stair slowly, savoring the velvet walls and the warm silence.

At the top, the library hummed around them, ordinary and wonderful, full of books that still needed returning and stories that still needed to be found.

SPARK's display showed one small image: a patchwork square, stitched gold.

"New ally confirmed," he said.

Maya took the stairs two at a time. Alana adjusted her notebook. Natalia looked back once at the brass handle panel before it clicked quietly closed.

Then she turned toward whatever the labyrinth held next.

THE END

(AND A BEGINNING)